



REFORM RUN: Prime Minister Manmohan Singh (right) with Deshmukh

MASS MOTIVES ANTYODAYA SCHEME

Food quotas to the poor are distributed in front of the village gram sabha, bringing transparency into the system.

SECOND HONEYMOON PACKAGE

By incentivising the delay of first pregnancy, the scheme aims to bring down birth and infant mortality rates.

DOCTOR TUMCHYA DARI

The doctor-at-your-doorstep initiative seeks to provide quality medical services to a large number of villagers.

TANTA MUKTA GAON

Inspired by Mahatma Gandhi, the programme rewards villages that resolve issues at the local level.

Redefining Governance

The state has launched a number of innovative schemes for rural welfare to make a difference where it matters

There were times when Raghunath Bhoje and his family could not even think of eating three square meals a day. But ever since he enrolled in the state Government's Antyodaya scheme, things have changed considerably. The scheme, launched to cut down rampant pilferage in the public distribution system in rural areas, has made it imperative for the local revenue officers to first assess the requirements of the villagers and then collect money to provide the same. Food quotas for three-six months are distributed to those living below the poverty line in front of the village gram sabha. "The scheme ensures that women in the family control the utilisation of food grain and eliminates the role of fair price shops," says Shekhar Gaikwad, additional collector of Nashik.

This scheme is among the several innovative welfare measures introduced by the state Government to curtail the problems faced by people. "We are trying to encourage novel ideas that stem from the complaints of the people," says Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh. Another ambitious project recently launched in Satara district—

Second Honeymoon Package—aims to keep the ballooning population under check. With 28 lakh people under its fold, the district health department has been encouraging newly-married couples to register for this package and avail monetary benefits merely by postponing their first pregnancy. The couples get Rs 5,000 if they delay the birth of their first child after marriage by two years, and Rs 7,500 if they do so for three years. "The money is sufficient for a couple to enjoy a second honeymoon," district health officer V.H. Mohite says. The scheme, if implemented successfully, is expected to bring down the birth rate from 17 to 15 per cent and the infant mortality rate from 31 to 15 per cent by 2010.

To improve the health of the rural populace, the state Public Health Department has launched the Doctor Tumchya Dari (doctor at your doorstep) scheme to provide quality medical services to villagers at their doorsteps. "The challenge would be to channelise the funds into the scheme so as to benefit a large number of people," says Archana Patil, deputy director of the department. Another pioneering

scheme, called the Mahatma Gandhi Tanta Mukta Gaon (dispute-free village programme), aims to reward villages that resolve disputes and squabbles at the local level without the need for any administrative or judicial intervention.

Though the Government has been on a scheme-launching spree, what remains to be seen is how many of these actually succeed. Going by the state's track record, the results are not very promising. Art of Living, an innovative programme for farmers in Vidarbha, which was launched to check the rising number of suicides, was a disaster as the farmers failed to relate to it. Another problem area is implementation, as the success of many such schemes depends on the moral standing of the beneficiaries. For instance, the very basis of the dispute-free village scheme is the setting up of a committee with unimpeachable integrity, which may not be possible to achieve.

The authorities say this time they are trying out practical and realistic measures. "We have realised that ground realities change after we draft these schemes. It is, therefore, imperative that people help us design a format for us to operate," says Deshmukh. So, while people come up with schemes that can benefit them, the bureaucrats are thinking out of the box to chalk out measures that strike a chord with the masses and help the Government achieve what it aims at—rural welfare.

by Prerana Thakurdesai